Kenya





Kenya straddles the equator on Africa's east coast. After nearly 40 years in power, the KANU party was soundly defeated in elections in 2002. Corruption is a serious issue.

GEOGRAPHY

A central plateau is divided by the Great Rift Valley. North of the equator is mainly semidesert. To the east lies a fertile coastal belt.

CLIMATE

The coast and the Great Rift Valley are hot and humid. The plateau interior is temperate. The northeastern desert is hot and dry. Rain usually falls April–May and October–November.

PEOPLE & SOCIETY

70 ethnic groups share about 40 languages. Strong clan and family links in rural areas are being weakened by urban migration. Poverty, severe drought, and years of high population growth exacerbate ethnic tensions.

INSIGHT: *Kenya has more than 50 game reserves, national parks, and marine reservations*

THE ECONOMY

Tourism: image damaged by 2008 post-election violence. Flowers, tea, and coffee are cash crops. Needs food aid. Diversified manufacturing sector. Sizable informal economy.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Kenya
DATE OF FORMATION: 1963
CAPITAL: Nairobi
POPULATION: 39.8 million
TOTAL AREA: 224,961 sq. miles (582,650 sq. km)
DENSITY: 182 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Kiswahili*, English*, other
RELIGIONS: Christian 60%, traditional beliefs 25%, other 9%, Muslim 6%
ETHNIC MIX: Other 42%, Kikuyu 20%, Luhya 14%, Luo 13%, Kalenjin 11%
GOVERNMENT: Mixed presidential–parliamentary system
CURRENCY: Kenya shilling = 100 cents